

Taricha torosa

California newt



Length 5–8 in (12.5–20 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding season Winter and spring
Status Least concern

Location W. USA (California)



California is particularly rich in salamanders and newts, and this species is one of over 20 that live in the state. Its rough, warty

body is brown or brick-red above, and yellow to orange below. During the breeding season, when these newts carry out mass migrations to ponds and streams, the males develop a smooth, slimy skin, black patches on their feet, and a swollen vent (cloaca). The California newt is protected by a toxic secretion that makes both its skin and flesh extremely poisonous. It is nocturnal and feeds on invertebrates of all kinds.



Pleurodeles waltl

Sharp-ribbed salamander



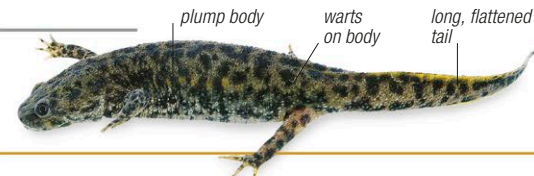
Length 6–12 in (15–30 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding season Any time, except cold weather
Status Near threatened

Location S.W. Europe, N.W. Africa



This mottled gray-green salamander is one of Europe's largest tailed

amphibians. Like most salamanders, it is protected by toxic skin secretions, but it also has sharply pointed ribs that project through its skin when it is held. Together with its chemical defenses, these help deter most predators. Sharp-ribbed salamanders are mainly nocturnal and spend their lives in water, except in times of drought, when they survive by hiding in mud until wetter conditions return. During the breeding season, females lay 200–300 eggs singly or in clumps, fastening them to water plants.



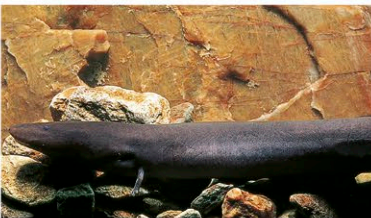
Amphiuma tridactylum

Three-toed amphiuma



Length 18–43 in (46–110 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding season Winter and spring
Status Least concern

Location C. and S. USA



This large, slimy salamander has a slender, eel-like body that is black, gray, or brown above, and pale gray below. The tail is flattened from side to side, and each of the tiny limbs has 3 toes. It inhabits ditches, swamps, streams, and ponds and, in periods of drought, it can survive buried in mud. Active at night, it feeds on worms and crayfish. This animal can deliver a painful bite.

Dicamptodon tenebrosus

Pacific giant salamander



Length 6½–13½ in (17–34 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding season Spring and fall
Status Least concern

Location S.W. Canada, N.W. USA



Active at night, this dark brown to black salamander, with light brown mottling, lives in wooded habitats in and around streams. It passes through an aquatic larval stage lasting for several years. When individuals reach maturity, they may become terrestrial. However, some never leave the water, becoming aquatic adults. Those that do leave the water are the world's largest terrestrial salamanders. In defense, this animal secretes noxious mucus from its tail. Populations have been adversely affected by the silting of streams.

12 or 13 costal grooves



Notophthalmus viridescens

Eastern newt



Length 2½–4½ in (6.5–11.5 cm)
Habit Largely terrestrial
Breeding season Variable
Status Least concern

Location E. Canada, E. USA



This common North American newt has a complex life cycle. It breeds in freshwater habitats, but instead of developing directly into adults, its larvae turn into specialized juvenile forms, called red eft. Red efts live on land—usually in grassland, mountain forests, and other damp habitats—and then return to water after 1–4 years, where they reach maturity. Outside the breeding season, adults live on land. During the adult and eft stages, these newts are protected from predators by highly toxic skin secretions.

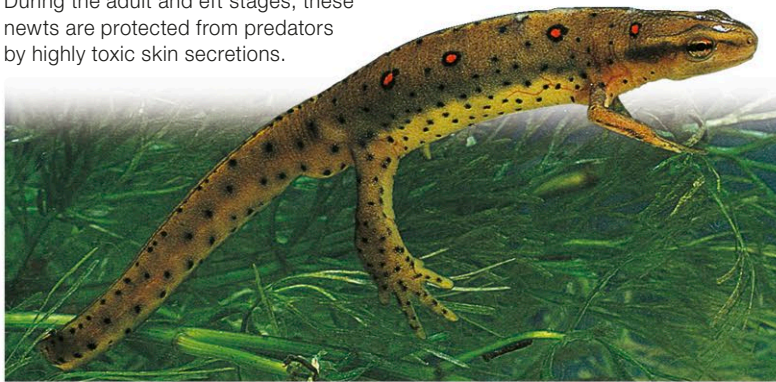


JUVENILE COLORATION

The young eastern newt, or the red eft, is bright red, orange, or brown all over, with black-edged red spots along its back, and rough skin. This terrestrial juvenile stage lasts for 1–4 years, after which the red eft returns to water to develop into an adult.

ADULT STAGE

This newt completes its development in water. Its upperside turns greenish yellow, with black-edged red spots, and its underside becomes yellow. The breeding male has a very deep tail, a swollen cloaca, and rough pads on the inside of its thighs.



Ambystoma tigrinum

Tiger salamander



Length 7–14 in (18–35 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding season Variable, after heavy rain
Status Least concern

Location North America



The stout-bodied tiger salamander is one of North America's most colorful amphibians, and is also one of the most locally varied. At least 6 subspecies are known: the eastern subspecies have a dappled pattern of black and yellow markings, but those farther west—including the one shown here—have larger yellow blotches or vertical bars. Adult tiger salamanders generally live on land, and hibernate in burrows dug by other animals. In early spring, once any ice has melted, they migrate to ponds, lakes, pools, and reservoirs to breed, sometimes in large numbers. The females lay up to 7,000 eggs in a single breeding season, and their larvae feed

mainly on invertebrates, although some individuals may become cannibalistic, growing larger mouths with extra teeth. In most areas, the young leave the water once they have developed adult bodies, but in some regions—particularly in the west—they may retain their larval form permanently, reproducing without taking up life on land. The chief predators of the tiger salamander are fish, which eat the larvae; however, in recent years, the species has suffered through pollution and habitat loss.

